

THE WORLD OF WORK IS CHANGING

Employment, business, and what it means to have a career today • WEEK 6 • LEVEL A

Think about what you want from your future. For most people, the answer involves some kind of work — a **career** that pays a **salary**, gives their life structure, and ideally brings them a sense of purpose. But the world of **employment** is changing faster than ever before. The rise of technology, the internet, and new ways of working mean that the jobs people do today look very different from those their parents or grandparents had. And the jobs that will exist in twenty years may look different again.

In the past, most people expected to work for the same company for their entire **career** — sometimes for thirty or forty years — before retiring with a **pension**. Today, the average person changes jobs several times in their working life. Many people choose to become **self-employed** or **freelance**, working for themselves rather than for a single employer. Others work remotely, managing their own deadlines from home rather than commuting to an office every day. The **workplace** is no longer just a physical building — it can be a kitchen table, a coffee shop, or a laptop on a beach.

What kind of worker are you — or would you like to be? Consider these situations:

1 Your employer offers you the choice between working in the office every day or working from home. What do you choose?

a I prefer the office — I like the structure, the social contact, and the clear separation between work and home life.

b I prefer remote work — I am more productive without the commute and I appreciate having flexible hours.

2 You have a great business idea. What do you do?

a I keep it to myself — starting a business is too risky and I prefer the security of employment.

b I research the idea carefully and consider becoming an entrepreneur — the risk is worth the reward.

Both answers are completely valid — and both reflect real and important choices that people make about their working lives. There is no single right way to work. What matters is finding a path that suits your skills, your personality, and your goals. This article explores some of the biggest changes happening in the world of work today, and what they mean for you.

■ TRADITIONAL EMPLOYMENT

- A fixed **salary** paid monthly, with clear terms of **employment**.
- A regular **commute** to a physical **workplace** or office.
- Set working hours — often nine to five — with little flexibility.
- A **pension** scheme and benefits such as sick pay and holiday pay.
- The chance of **promotion** within a company structure.
- Greater job security — harder to be made **redundant**.

■ FREELANCE / SELF-EMPLOYED

- **Freelance** or **self-employed** income — flexible but less predictable.
- **Remote work** from home or any location, without a daily **commute**.
- **Flexible hours** that you manage yourself around deadlines.
- You organise your own **pension** and do not receive automatic benefits.
- **Career** growth depends on your own initiative and networking.
- Less security — income can change, and contracts may be short-term.

60%

of workers say flexible hours improve their productivity

1 in 7

workers in the UK is now self-employed or freelance

4.5x

more innovation in companies that encourage collaboration

77%

of employees say motivation falls when not recognised

How the Workplace Is Changing

One of the biggest changes in recent years has been the growth of **remote work**. Before 2020, working from home was unusual in most industries. Then the global pandemic changed everything almost overnight. Millions of workers were suddenly required to work from home, and many discovered that they were just as productive — or even more productive — without the daily **commute** and office distractions. Many companies have since made remote work a permanent option, and some have adopted a hybrid model where employees split their time between home and the office.

Flexible hours have also become much more common. Rather than requiring everyone to start and finish at the same time, many employers now allow their staff to choose when they work, as long as they meet their deadlines. This has been particularly valuable for parents, carers, and anyone who needs to manage personal responsibilities alongside their **career**. Better **work-life balance** — the feeling that work does not take over every part of life — is now one of the top priorities for many job seekers, especially younger workers.

Innovation, Entrepreneurship, and Creativity at Work

Innovation — the ability to think of new ideas and find better ways of doing things — is one of the most valued skills in the modern **workplace**. Companies that encourage their employees to **collaborate**, share ideas, and take creative risks tend to perform better than those that do not. Some of the world's most successful businesses — from small start-ups to large corporations — were built on a single innovative idea that someone was brave enough to pursue.

An **entrepreneur** is someone who starts their own business, usually with a new idea or product. Entrepreneurship can be exciting and rewarding, but it also requires a high tolerance for risk. Many new businesses fail within their first few years — but those that succeed can grow rapidly and create **employment** for many others. Governments around the world have recognised this and increasingly offer support for new entrepreneurs through funding,

training programmes, and apprenticeship schemes.

"The biggest risk is not taking any risk. In a world that is changing quickly, the only strategy that is guaranteed to fail is not taking risks."

— Mark Zuckerberg, co-founder of Facebook

What Makes a Good Workplace?

A good salary is important — but research consistently shows that money alone is not enough to keep workers happy or motivated. People also want to feel that their work is meaningful, that they are learning and growing, and that their efforts are recognised. Motivation falls sharply when employees feel they are being ignored, undervalued, or passed over for promotion. A positive workplace culture — one where people feel safe to speak up, collaborate freely, and be creative — makes a huge difference to both individual wellbeing and overall productivity.

Shift work — where employees work in rotating patterns that may include nights, weekends, and early mornings — is common in healthcare, hospitality, and manufacturing. While it provides employment for millions of people, it can make work-life balance more difficult to achieve. On the other hand, some workers prefer shift work because it gives them free time during the week.

For young people entering the workforce, an apprenticeship can be an excellent alternative to university. Rather than studying full-time, apprentices earn a salary while learning a trade or profession on the job. This allows them to build skills and experience at the same time — and to avoid the significant debt that university can bring. Many large companies actively recruit apprentices, and some go on to build very successful long-term careers.

The Future of Work: What Comes Next?

Artificial intelligence and automation are already changing many industries — and this trend will only continue. Some jobs that exist today may disappear over the next decade, particularly those that involve repetitive, routine tasks. However, new jobs are also being created — in technology, creative industries, healthcare, and renewable energy, among others. The workers who will thrive are likely to be those who are adaptable, who continue learning throughout their careers, and who are able to collaborate effectively with both people and technology.

Whatever path you choose — traditional employment, freelance work, or entrepreneurship — the most important thing is to stay curious, keep developing your skills, and never stop looking for ways to innovate. The world of work belongs to those who are willing to adapt to it — and to those brave enough to try to change it.

ACTIVITIES

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Read the article and answer True (T) or False (F).

- 1 In the past, most people expected to stay in the same job for their whole career.
- 2 Freelance workers automatically receive a pension and sick pay from their employer.
- 3 The COVID-19 pandemic made remote work much more common.
- 4 Flexible hours are only useful for parents with young children.
- 5 Apprentices earn a salary while they learn their trade.
- 6 Research shows that a good salary is the only thing that keeps workers motivated.

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Match the highlighted words in the article to their meanings.

- 1 a regular payment received for doing a job, usually monthly
- 2 the daily journey from home to work and back
- 3 working for yourself rather than for one employer
- 4 someone who starts their own business with a new idea
- 5 the feeling that work and personal life are in a healthy balance
- 6 a training programme where you earn while you learn a skill

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Read the article again and answer these questions in full sentences.

- 1 Give two reasons why someone might prefer remote work over office work.
- 2 What does the article say about the risks of entrepreneurship?
- 3 Apart from salary, what do workers want from their jobs?
- 4 How might artificial intelligence affect jobs in the future?

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Think about your ideal future job. Write 5–7 sentences describing it.

Use these phrases to help you:

I would like to work as ... / I prefer ... because ... / My ideal workplace would ... / I think work-life balance is important because ...

■ TALKING POINTS

Would you rather be employed by a company or work for yourself? What are the risks and rewards?

Do you think working from home is better or worse than going to an office? Why?

What job do you think will be the most important in the world in 20 years' time?

Is money or job satisfaction more important when choosing a career? Can you have both?